Security Optimization Assessment — Microsoft Defender (Suite / XDR)

Implementation Solution Guide

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Executive Summary — Security Optimization Assessment: Microsoft Defender (Suite / XDR)

White-label · Assessments

A deployed product is not an optimized one — and a *suite* multiplies the problem. Microsoft Defender XDR ties together five pillars — **endpoint, identity, email/collaboration, cloud apps, and cloud** — into one portal, one incident queue, and one unified role model. In most tenants some pillars are fully onboarded, others barely; **unified RBAC** is unconfigured so people over- or under-see; **incident correlation** is weak because a pillar isn't feeding signal; and the **suite-wide Secure Score** stagnates. This **Security Optimization Assessment** takes a **read-only** look across the whole suite, scores it against Microsoft's recommended baseline, and hands you a **prioritized, risk-ranked findings report** telling you what to fix, in what order.

This package is written for an administrator with no prior assessment experience. It is **read-only by design** — every script observes and reports via **Microsoft Graph (Security)** and **Az**; **none change your tenant**. The paired remediation work (closing the gaps) is a separate, pilot-first effort delivered by the **Remediation Playbook for Defender Security Optimization Assessments**.

What you get

- A plain-language **Solution Overview** of Microsoft Defender XDR, the four assessment domains (cross-pillar coverage, unified RBAC, incident correlation, suite-wide Secure Score), and the scoring model.
- A **Requirements Guide** with verify / implement-if-missing for every solution-specific prerequisite (category-wide prerequisites live once in the Global Requirements).
- An **Implementation Guide** of exact, ordered steps to run the assessment end to end — enumerate, score, and report — following **Assess** → **Configure** → **Pilot** → **Validate** → **Expand**.
- Five **PowerShell scripts** (Graph / Security + Az) — all **read-only** — for discovery, control validation, suite-wide posture scoring, a unified-RBAC audit, and the prioritized findings report with drift versus a saved baseline.
- **Testing** and **Troubleshooting** guides so the run is repeatable and trustworthy.

What this delivers

A **scored, evidence-backed picture** of your Defender suite posture: which of the five pillars are onboarded and licensed, whether unified RBAC is configured to least privilege, whether incidents are correlating across pillars, and where the suite-wide Secure Score leaks points. The output is a **prioritized remediation backlog** — highest-risk gaps first — ready to hand to the Remediation Playbook.

The standard deployment model

Assess → **Configure** → **Pilot** → **Validate** → **Expand** — assess the current suite configuration, produce and validate the findings, then expand scope (more pillars/roles) and re-run to trend the score.

Boundary

This assessment supplies **the evidence and the technical score**, not the authorization. **Risk-acceptance** of any finding, **remediation priority** in your context, and any **regulatory / records / incident-response** determination are the customer's security, compliance, and SOC functions' decisions. Licensing, plan, and preview facts are flagged **verify** — confirm current availability in your tenant.

Effort

A competent administrator can run the full suite assessment in a focused engagement. It is **repeatable** — re-run on a schedule to trend the posture score as pillars are onboarded and RBAC matures.

1. Solution Overview — Security Optimization Assessment: Microsoft Defender (Suite / XDR)

What Microsoft Defender XDR is

Microsoft Defender XDR is the **unified security suite** in the Microsoft Defender portal (`security.microsoft.com`). It brings five protection pillars into one experience:

- **Endpoint** — Microsoft Defender for Endpoint (device onboarding, EDR, vulnerability management).
- **Identity** — Microsoft Defender for Identity (on-prem AD / Entra identity threat detection).
- **Email & collaboration** — Microsoft Defender for Office 365 (EOP + MDO: anti-phish, Safe Links/Attachments).
- **Cloud apps** — Microsoft Defender for Cloud Apps (CASB — connectors, session/OAuth policies).
- **Cloud** — Microsoft Defender for Cloud (Azure/multicloud workload and posture signal surfaced into XDR).

On top of the pillars, XDR provides:

- **Unified incidents** — alerts from all pillars are **correlated** into a single incident with an end-to-end attack story.
- **Unified RBAC** — one role model (the Microsoft Defender XDR Unified role-based access control) that governs who can see and act across the pillars, replacing per-product permission silos.
- **Suite-wide Microsoft Secure Score** — a single posture score spanning the identity, device, apps, and data controls across the suite.

Why this assessment matters

A suite is only as strong as its weakest pillar and its glue. Common gaps: endpoint is onboarded but identity sensors are not, so lateral-movement detections never fire; email protection runs on default policies; cloud apps is on but unconnected; unified RBAC is left at legacy per-product roles so analysts either can't see across the incident or can see far too much; and the suite Secure Score plateaus because nobody works it. **None of this is visible from the incident queue** — you have to **enumerate onboarding/licensing per pillar, the RBAC model, incident-correlation settings, and the Secure Score, compare to the recommended baseline, and score it**.

That is what this assessment does. It is **read-only** — it changes nothing — and produces a **prioritized, risk-ranked findings report** across the four domains so remediation goes to the highest-risk gaps first. Because the sibling assessments (**Defender for Cloud Apps** and **Defender for Cloud**) go deep on their pillars, this suite assessment focuses on **cross-pillar coverage and the glue** and points to those deep-dive assessments where a pillar needs its own review.

The four assessment domains and how they are scored

1. **Cross-pillar coverage** — Are all five pillars **onboarded and licensed**? Endpoint devices onboarded, identity sensors deployed, MDO policies present, cloud-apps connected, cloud plans on? Which pillars are dark?

2. **Unified RBAC** — Is Defender XDR Unified RBAC **activated** and are roles scoped to least privilege, or is the tenant still on legacy per-product permissions / broad Entra roles? *RBAC model availability — verify current.*

3. **Incident correlation** — Are the pillars feeding signal so incidents **correlate across products**? Are alert-to-incident and cross-pillar settings on? Is the incident queue producing multi-pillar incidents (evidence of correlation) rather than isolated single-product alerts?

4. **Suite-wide Secure Score** — What is the Microsoft Secure Score across the suite, and are high-impact improvement actions being worked or is there a stale backlog?

Each domain is scored against the **best-practice reference baseline** named in the Global Requirements (Microsoft security baseline / Secure Score / Zero-Trust guidance — *baselines evolve; verify against current Microsoft guidance*). Domain scores roll up into an overall posture score, and every gap becomes a finding with a **risk rank** (severity × exposure).

What is in scope

• **Reading** the suite configuration: pillar onboarding/licensing, unified RBAC role assignments, incident/correlation settings, and Microsoft Secure Score — via Graph (Security) and Az.

• **Scoring** that configuration against the recommended baseline across the four domains.

• **Producing** a prioritized, risk-ranked findings report with a saved baseline for trending.

What is out of scope (and where it lives)

• **Making changes / closing the gaps** — the **Remediation Playbook for Defender Security Optimization Assessments** (pilot-first, `-WhatIf`-gated).

• **Deep single-pillar review** — the **Security Optimization Assessment — Defender for Cloud Apps** and **— Defender for Cloud** solutions (and their onboarding/optimization siblings for endpoint/identity/email).

• **First-time unified onboarding** — the **Microsoft Defender XDR Deployment — Unified Onboarding** solution.

• **SOC operations on the correlated incidents** — the **SOC Onboarding (Sentinel + Defender XDR)** and **Threat Hunting (KQL)** solutions.

• **Regulatory, records, incident-response, and risk-acceptance decisions** — the customer's compliance/legal/SOC functions.

Connections and authentication used

• The **Microsoft Defender portal** (`security.microsoft.com`) → **Settings** (per-pillar onboarding, Permissions & roles / Unified RBAC), **Incidents**, and **Secure Score** (for manual confirmation).

• **Microsoft Graph** (read-only Security scopes such as `SecurityEvents.Read.All`, and directory read scopes such as `RoleManagement.Read.Directory` / `Directory.Read.All` for the RBAC audit) and **Az** for the cloud pillar. *Verify current scope names and availability.*

• Least-privilege roles: **Security Reader** / **Global Reader** are sufficient for this read-only assessment (per Global Requirements G2).

The standard deployment model

> ***Assess*** *the current suite configuration (pillar onboarding, unified RBAC, incident correlation, Secure Score) →* ***Configure*** *the assessment scope and baseline reference →* ***Pilot*** *the run and review the findings →* ***Validate*** *the score and findings with the security owner →* ***Expand*** *scope (pillars/roles) and re-run to trend. Repeatable pattern:* ***Assess*** *→* ***Configure*** *→* ***Pilot*** *→* ***Validate*** *→* ***Expand****, entirely* ***read-only****.*

2. Requirements — Security Optimization Assessment: Microsoft Defender (Suite / XDR)

The category-wide prerequisites (the target tenant, read-only assessor access, Graph/Az access, licensing, scope/baseline, output handling, remediation ownership) are documented once in `global-requirements-assessments.md` — read that first. This section lists only the prerequisites **specific to assessing the Defender suite**. Each item: **Description / Why required / How to verify / How to implement if missing.**

R1. Microsoft Defender XDR portal is active

Description: The unified Microsoft Defender portal (`security.microsoft.com`) is active for the tenant, with at least one pillar onboarded. **Why required:** The suite assessment reads unified incidents, Secure Score, and RBAC from this portal; there must be a suite to assess. **How to verify:** Sign in to `security.microsoft.com`; confirm **Incidents**, **Secure score**, and **Settings** load. **How to implement if missing:** Confirm licensing (R2) and onboard at least one pillar. First-time unified onboarding is out of scope — use the *Microsoft Defender XDR Deployment — Unified Onboarding* solution. Record a dark suite as a finding.

R2. Licensing across the five pillars

Description: The licenses/plans for endpoint, identity, email/collaboration, cloud apps, and cloud (e.g. Defender for Endpoint P1/P2, Defender for Identity, Defender for Office 365 P1/P2, Defender for Cloud Apps, Defender for Cloud plans). **Why required:** A pillar's posture is only assessable when its plan is licensed and enabled; unlicensed pillars are coverage findings. **How to verify:** In the Microsoft 365 admin

center / billing, confirm which pillar plans are assigned. *License-to-feature mapping changes — verify current entitlements.* **How to implement if missing:** Record any unlicensed pillar as a **coverage-gap finding** ("license/onboard to gain this pillar"), not an omission.

R3. Read-only Security Reader / Global Reader access (and RBAC read)

Description: A read-only role sufficient to enumerate per-pillar configuration, unified RBAC role assignments, incidents, and Secure Score. **Why required:** The assessment must prove it changes nothing; read-only roles are sufficient for every script here. **How to verify:** Entra → **Roles and administrators** for Security Reader / Global Reader. Confirm you can view (not edit) **Settings** → **Permissions & roles** and the incident queue. **How to implement if missing:** Assign **Security Reader** and/or **Global Reader**. Do **not** grant write/admin roles for the assessment.

R4. Microsoft Graph read scopes consented (Security + RoleManagement)

Description: Read-only Graph scopes — Security read (e.g. `SecurityEvents.Read.All`) and role/directory read (e.g. `RoleManagement.Read.Directory`, `RoleManagement.Read.All`, `Directory.Read.All`) for the unified-RBAC audit. **Why required:** The discovery, validation, scoring, RBAC-audit, and reporting scripts collect configuration through Graph. **How to verify:** `Connect-MgGraph -Scopes "SecurityEvents.Read.All","RoleManagement.Read.Directory","Directory.Read.All"` succeeds and `SOAXDR-Discovery.ps1` runs. *Verify current scope names.* **How to implement if missing:** Have an administrator consent the read-only scopes. Never request write scopes for this assessment.

R5. Az access for the cloud pillar

Description: Az PowerShell (`Az.Accounts`, `Az.Security`) reachable so the cloud pillar's plan/coverage signal can be read. **Why required:** Cross-pillar coverage includes the cloud pillar (Defender for Cloud); reading it requires Az. **How to verify:** `Connect-AzAccount` succeeds; the discovery script's cloud-pillar section returns without error. **How to implement if missing:** `Install-Module Az -Scope CurrentUser`. If Azure is genuinely not in use, record the cloud pillar as "not applicable" rather than a gap — note it in the scope.

R6. A defined assessment scope and a secure output location

Description: An agreed scope (which pillars, which role assignments, which subscriptions) and a secure place to store the findings report and the saved baseline. **Why required:** Scope keeps the score comparable; the findings report is sensitive (Global Requirements G5, G7). **How to verify:** The scope is documented; a restricted location exists for `SOAXDR-*.json` outputs and the report. **How to implement if missing:** Agree the scope with the security owner before running; create a restricted output location and point the scripts at it.

Global Requirements — Assessments (category-level)

These requirements apply to every solution in the Assessments category (Security Optimization Assessments, remediation playbooks, and cross-cutting security assessments). Published once at the

category level so listings stay small. Confirm these before running any assessment. Each entry: Description / Why / Verify / Implement-if-missing.

> *An assessment observes and scores; it does not change your tenant. Every assessment script here is **read-only** (the paired remediation work is separate and pilot-first). Scope, risk-acceptance, and remediation-priority decisions belong to the customer's security/compliance owners — the assessment supplies the evidence, not the authorization.*

G1. The workload/tenant being assessed

Description: An active Microsoft 365 / Entra tenant and/or Azure subscription(s) hosting the products in scope. Why: There is nothing to assess without the target environment. Verify: Sign in to the relevant portal(s) (`security.microsoft.com`, `portal.azure.com`) as an administrator. Implement: Ensure the target tenant/subscription exists and the products under assessment are deployed (even partially — assessing coverage gaps is the point).

G2. Read-only assessor access (least privilege)

Description: A read-only role sufficient to enumerate configuration — e.g. Security Reader, Global Reader, and/or Reader at the Azure scope. Why: An assessment must never require write access; read-only proves it changes nothing. Verify: Entra -> `Roles and administrators`; confirm Security Reader / Global Reader (and Azure Reader where cloud resources are assessed). Implement: Assign the read-only roles; do not grant write/admin roles for the assessment itself.

G3. Microsoft Graph / Az / management API access

Description: Microsoft Graph (Security), Azure Resource Manager, and product-specific management APIs reachable with the assessor identity. Why: The assessment scripts collect configuration and posture via these APIs. Verify: `Connect-MgGraph` (read scopes) and `Connect-AzAccount` succeed; the assessment discovery script runs. *Verify current API/permission scopes.* Implement: Consent the read-only Graph scopes; ensure network access to the Microsoft endpoints.

G4. Licensing for the products in scope

Description: The licenses/plans for the products being assessed (e.g. Defender for Endpoint/Identity/Office 365/Cloud Apps plans, Defender for Cloud plans). Why: Some posture/configuration is only present (and only assessable) when the plan is enabled; the assessment flags plan gaps too. Verify: Confirm the relevant plans in the admin/billing portal. *Verify current plan/feature mapping.* Implement: Note unlicensed products as findings (a coverage gap) rather than skipping them silently.

G5. Scope definition and a point-in-time baseline

Description: A defined assessment scope (which products, subscriptions, and users) and the understanding that results are a point-in-time snapshot. Why: Scope keeps the assessment bounded and the score comparable; posture drifts, so results are dated. Verify: The scope is documented; the assessment records the run date. Implement: Agree the scope before running; re-run periodically to trend the score.

G6. Best-practice reference baseline

Description: The best-practice / benchmark the assessment scores against (Microsoft security baselines, Secure Score, CIS/Zero-Trust as applicable). Why: A score is only meaningful against a reference; the assessment states which baseline it uses. Verify: The reference baseline is named in the findings. *Baselines evolve — verify against current Microsoft guidance.* Implement: Use the documented baseline; note where organizational policy intentionally deviates.

G7. Output handling and confidentiality

Description: A place to store the findings report and an understanding that it may contain sensitive posture detail. Why: Assessment output is a roadmap of your weaknesses; it must be handled as sensitive. Verify: A secure destination for the report exists; access is restricted. Implement: Store findings securely; share on a need-to-know basis. *Risk-acceptance of any finding is the customer's decision.*

G8. Remediation ownership (for the paired remediation)

Description: Named owners for acting on findings (the remediation is separate, pilot-first work). Why: An assessment only creates value when someone owns closing the gaps. Verify: Remediation owners are identified; the Remediation Playbook solution is available for the fixes. Implement: Assign owners; use the Remediation Playbook (pilot-first, -WhatIf-gated) to close findings and re-score.

The deployment model (all solutions): Assess -> Configure -> Pilot -> Validate -> Expand.

3. Implementation — Security Optimization Assessment: Microsoft Defender (Suite / XDR)

This is the exact, ordered procedure to run the suite assessment end to end. It is **read-only** — you enumerate configuration, score it, and produce a findings report; you change nothing in the tenant.

Naming convention. Every artifact you create uses `<Purpose> – <Scope> – <Stage>`. Use these exact names in the scripts, testing, and the report:

- Assessment scope record → `SOA Scope – Defender Suite – Assess`
- Baseline configuration snapshot → `Posture Baseline – Defender Suite – Assess`
- Posture score record → `Posture Score – Defender Suite – Pilot`
- Prioritized findings report → `Findings Report – Defender Suite – Validate`

> *Placeholders use `contoso.onmicrosoft.com`. Substitute your tenant. Confirm the prerequisites in Section 2 and the Global Requirements before starting.*

Stage 1 — Assess (define scope and capture the baseline)

Step 1.1 — Record the assessment scope

1. Open a working document named `SOA Scope – Defender Suite – Assess`.

2. Record: the tenant, which of the five pillars are in scope (and any marked not-applicable, e.g. no Azure → cloud pillar N/A), the **run date**, and the **best-practice reference baseline** (Global Requirements G6 — *verify current Microsoft guidance*).

3. Confirm your account has **Security Reader** / **Global Reader**, the Graph read scopes, and Az access (Section 2, R3/R4/R5).

Step 1.2 — Sign in and confirm the suite

1. Browse to `https://security.microsoft.com`; confirm **Incidents**, **Secure score**, and **Settings** load (R1).

2. Note under **Settings** → **Permissions & roles** whether **Unified RBAC** is activated (R3).

Step 1.3 — Capture the configuration baseline (read-only)

1. Open PowerShell in the `scripts/` folder.

2. Connect read-only:

```
Connect-MgGraph -Scopes "SecurityEvents.Read.All","RoleManagement.Read.Directory","Directory.Read.All"
Connect-AzAccount
```

1. Run discovery and save the snapshot as the baseline:

```
.\SOAXDR-Discovery.ps1 -OutputPath ".\Posture Baseline - Defender Suite - Assess.json"
```

1. This enumerates per-pillar onboarding/licensing signal, unified-RBAC role assignments, incident/correlation evidence, and Microsoft Secure Score. It **makes no changes**. Keep the JSON as `Posture Baseline – Defender Suite – Assess`.

Stage 2 — Configure (set the scoring reference)

Step 2.1 — Confirm the four assessment domains and weights

1. The scoring model covers: **cross-pillar coverage**, **unified RBAC**, **incident correlation**, and **suite-wide Secure Score**.

2. Review the default weights in `SOAXDR-Score.ps1` (documented in its header). If the security owner wants a different emphasis, record it in `SOA Scope – Defender Suite – Assess` so runs stay comparable.

Step 2.2 — Validate that best-practice controls are present (read-only)

1. Run the control validation, passing which pillars you confirmed onboarded and whether unified RBAC is on:

```
.\SOAXDR-Validate.ps1 -BaselinePath ".\Posture Baseline - Defender Suite - Assess.json" `
    -PillarsOnboarded @('endpoint','identity','email','cloudapps','cloud') `
    -UnifiedRbacActivated $true -OutputPath ".\SOAXDR-validation.json"
```

1. This checks, per domain, whether the recommended controls exist (all in-scope pillars onboarded; unified RBAC activated with least-privilege roles; incidents correlating cross-pillar; Secure Score above a floor). Each check returns **Pass / Gap** with evidence — it fixes nothing.

Stage 3 — Pilot (score the posture)

Step 3.1 — Audit unified RBAC

1. Run the RBAC audit (read-only):

```
.\SOAXDR-RBACAudit.ps1 -OutputPath ".\rbac-audit.json"
```

1. This enumerates privileged directory-role assignments relevant to the Defender suite and flags broad/over-privileged assignments — the evidence behind the unified-RBAC domain.

Step 3.2 — Compute the posture score

1. Run the scorer against the validation output:

```
.\SOAXDR-Score.ps1 -ValidationPath ".\SOAXDR-validation.json" -OutputPath ".\Posture Score - Defender S
```

1. This produces per-domain scores and an overall suite posture score, saved as `Posture Score – Defender Suite – Pilot`. Scoring is deterministic. Record the run date.

Stage 4 — Validate (produce and review the findings report)

Step 4.1 — Generate the prioritized findings report

1. Run the report generator (add `-PriorReportPath` on re-runs for drift):

```
.\SOAXDR-Report.ps1 -ValidationPath ".\SOAXDR-validation.json" -ScorePath ".\Posture Score - Defender S
```

1. The report lists every finding with its **domain**, **severity**, **risk rank**, **evidence**, and a **remediation pointer** to the Remediation Playbook (and, where a pillar needs a deep dive, a pointer to that pillar's assessment), plus **drift**.

Step 4.2 — Review with the security owner

1. Walk through `Findings Report – Defender Suite – Validate` with the named security owner.

2. The owner confirms **risk-acceptance** and **remediation priority** (their decisions). Record accepted-risk items with justification and expiry.

3. Store the report securely (Global Requirements G7).

Stage 5 — Expand (broaden scope and trend)

Step 5.1 — Widen the scope and re-run

1. Expand `SOA Scope – Defender Suite – Assess` to additional pillars/roles/subscriptions as they onboard.

2. Re-run Steps 1.3 → 4.1. With the prior baseline retained, `SOAXDR-Report.ps1` shows the **drift** since the last run.

Step 5.2 — Hand off and schedule

1. Hand `Findings Report – Defender Suite – Validate` to the **Remediation Playbook** to close the gaps pilot-first; use the per-pillar deep-dive assessments where a pillar needs its own review.

2. Schedule the assessment on a cadence (for example quarterly) so the suite Secure Score and coverage trend over time.

Everything above is read-only. If any script attempts a write or requests a write scope/role, stop — it should not.

5. Testing — Security Optimization Assessment: Microsoft Defender (Suite / XDR)

These procedures validate that the suite assessment **ran correctly and completely** — that the enumeration is trustworthy, the scoring is reproducible, and the findings report is sound. The assessment is read-only, so "testing" proves the *evidence* is reliable. Each test has a **pass/fail gate**. Reference the scripts by the names used in Section 3.

Test 1 — Read-only connection succeeds

Procedure: Run the `Connect-MgGraph`/`Connect-AzAccount` commands, then `.\SOAXDR-Discovery.ps1`. **Pass:** The script completes and writes `Posture Baseline - Defender Suite - Assess.json`; no write scope/role was used. **Fail:** A permissions error, or a prompt for a write scope — re-check R3/R4/R5.

Test 2 — Discovery captured all four domains and five pillars

Procedure: Open the baseline JSON. **Pass:** It contains sections for **cross-pillar coverage** (with a per-pillar entry for each of the five), **unified RBAC**, **incident correlation**, and **suite-wide Secure Score** — even where a pillar is dark or marked N/A (that is itself a finding/note). **Fail:** A domain or pillar section is missing entirely. Re-run; confirm portal access.

Test 3 — RBAC audit enumerates privileged assignments

Procedure: Run `.\SOAXDR-RBACAudit.ps1 -OutputPath ".\rbac-audit.json"`. **Pass:** The output lists privileged directory-role assignments and flags broad/over-privileged ones (or notes none found). **Fail:** The script cannot enumerate role assignments — confirm `RoleManagement.Read.Directory` / `Directory.Read.All` (R4).

Test 4 — Control validation returns evidence, not just a verdict

Procedure: Run `.\SOAXDR-Validate.ps1 -BaselinePath ... -PillarsOnboarded ... -UnifiedRbacActivated ...`. **Pass:** Each domain check returns **Pass** or **Gap** with evidence (e.g. "identity pillar: not onboarded", "unified RBAC: legacy per-product", "Secure Score = 55%"). **Fail:** A check returns a verdict with no evidence, or throws.

Test 5 — Scoring is reproducible

Procedure: Run `.\SOAXDR-Score.ps1` twice against the **same** validation output. **Pass:** Both runs produce the same per-domain and overall scores (deterministic). **Fail:** Scores differ for identical input — a defect; do not trust the score until reproducible.

Test 6 — Findings report is prioritized and traceable

Procedure: Run `.\SOAXDR-Report.ps1 ...` and open the report. **Pass:** Findings are sorted by **risk rank**; each names its **domain**, **severity**, **evidence**, and a **remediation pointer** (to the Remediation Playbook, or to a per-pillar deep-dive assessment where relevant). **Fail:** Findings are unsorted, or a finding

lacks evidence or a remediation pointer.

Test 7 — Drift is detected across runs

Procedure: After a second run, confirm `SOAXDR-Report.ps1` compares to the prior report/baseline. **Pass:** The report shows **new**, **resolved**, and **unchanged** findings (or notes "no prior baseline" on the first run). **Fail:** No drift comparison when a prior baseline exists — check `-PriorReportPath`.

Test 8 — Output is stored securely

Procedure: Confirm the report and score/baseline JSON live in the restricted location agreed in R6. **Pass:** Files are in the secure destination with restricted access. **Fail:** The report is in an open location — move it (Global Requirements G7).

Exit criteria

All eight tests pass, the security owner has reviewed `Findings Report – Defender Suite – Validate`, and risk-acceptance/priority decisions are recorded. The backlog is ready for the Remediation Playbook (and the per-pillar deep-dive assessments where needed).

6. Troubleshooting — Security Optimization Assessment: Microsoft Defender (Suite / XDR)

Common failures when running the suite assessment, in **symptom** → **cause** → **fix** form. All fixes stay read-only.

`Connect-MgGraph` fails or needs admin consent

Symptom: The connect command errors, or a consent screen requires an administrator. **Cause:** The read scopes (`SecurityEvents.Read.All`, `RoleManagement.Read.Directory`, `Directory.Read.All`) are not consented, or your account lacks them. **Fix:** Have an administrator grant admin consent for the read-only scopes once. Confirm **Security Reader** / **Global Reader** (R3). *Verify current scope names.*

A pillar shows "not onboarded" that you believe is live

Symptom: Discovery marks e.g. the identity pillar dark, but you think sensors are deployed. **Cause 1:** The signal the script reads (licensing/onboarding indicator) is not visible to the read role. **Cause 2:** The pillar is genuinely partially onboarded (some sensors, not all) — a real finding. **Fix:** Cross-check in the Defender portal **Settings** for that pillar. If the portal shows it onboarded and the script does not, re-check scopes. Partial onboarding is a legitimate coverage finding.

RBAC audit lists nothing / only a few roles

Symptom: `SOAXDR-RBACAudit.ps1` returns an empty or tiny set. **Cause 1:** `RoleManagement.Read.Directory` / `Directory.Read.All` not consented. **Cause 2:** The tenant genuinely has few privileged assignments (good). **Fix:** Verify the scopes (R4). Cross-check in Entra →

Roles and administrators. If the portal shows assignments the script does not, the scope is missing.

Unified RBAC "not activated" but you use Defender roles

Symptom: Validation flags unified RBAC as not activated although people can act in the portal. **Cause:** The tenant is on **legacy per-product permissions** or broad Entra roles rather than the Defender XDR Unified RBAC model. **Fix:** Confirm under **Settings** → **Permissions & roles** whether Unified RBAC is activated. Legacy per-product permissions are a legitimate finding ("activate unified RBAC for least-privilege cross-pillar access"). *Verify current RBAC model availability.*

Secure Score reads low or "not available"

Symptom: The Secure Score domain shows no score or a surprisingly low one. **Cause:** A pillar was recently onboarded and the score is still populating, or improvement actions genuinely aren't worked. **Fix:** Allow a warm-up window and re-run (Global Requirements G5). A genuinely low score with a stale backlog is a legitimate finding.

Incident-correlation evidence is empty

Symptom: The incident-correlation domain shows no multi-pillar incidents. **Cause 1:** Only one pillar is feeding signal, so there is nothing to correlate (a coverage problem upstream). **Cause 2:** The tenant is quiet (few incidents in the sample window). **Fix:** If pillars are dark, the correlation gap is downstream of the coverage gap — fix coverage first. If pillars are onboarded and the queue is simply quiet, note it and re-sample over a longer window.

Az cloud-pillar section errors

Symptom: The cloud-pillar part of discovery throws. **Cause:** `Az` not installed, or no Azure subscription in context. **Fix:** `Install-Module Az -Scope CurrentUser`; `Connect-AzAccount`. If Azure is not in use, mark the cloud pillar **N/A** in the scope rather than a gap (R5).

Findings contradict the live portal

Symptom: A finding disagrees with what the portal shows now. **Cause:** Posture is a **point-in-time snapshot**; the baseline predates your view, or a change was made after the run. **Fix:** Re-run discovery to refresh the baseline, then re-score. Trust the dated baseline over memory (Global Requirements G5).

7. Best Practices — Security Optimization Assessment: Microsoft Defender (Suite / XDR)

Field-proven guidance for running this suite assessment well and keeping the result trustworthy over time.

Keep it read-only and provably so

- Run with **Security Reader / Global Reader** only. If a script ever requests a write scope or role, treat it as a defect and stop — this assessment must prove it changed nothing.

• Record the scopes/roles used alongside the findings report as evidence of read-only execution.

Assess the glue, not just the pillars

• The value of this assessment over the single-pillar ones is the **cross-pillar coverage**, **unified RBAC**, and **incident correlation** — the glue that makes XDR more than five separate products. Give the glue domains real attention; a fully-onboarded pillar with broken correlation still leaves you blind.

• Where a pillar needs a deep review, point to its **dedicated assessment** (Cloud Apps / Cloud) rather than duplicating that depth here.

Treat unlicensed / dark pillars honestly

• A dark or unlicensed pillar is a **coverage finding** ("license/onboard to gain this pillar"), and onboarding has a licensing cost the customer accepts. Mark genuinely not-applicable pillars (e.g. no Azure → cloud pillar) as **N/A** in the scope so they don't read as gaps forever.

Least privilege is the point of unified RBAC

• Flag both **over-privileged** (analysts with broad Global/Security Admin) and **under-privileged** (analysts who can't see across an incident) as findings — unified RBAC exists to fix both. Broad standing privilege is a high-risk finding; prioritize it.

Make the score comparable across runs

• Keep the **scoring weights** fixed between runs (in `SOAXDR-Score.ps1`). If the owner changes a weight, record it in `SOA Scope – Defender Suite – Assess`.

• Re-use the saved baseline so `SOAXDR-Report.ps1` can show **drift** — a rising suite Secure Score and pillars going from dark to onboarded is the real proof of progress.

Allow warm-up and account for correlation latency

• Secure Score and incident correlation **take time to reflect changes**. If a pillar was recently onboarded, note the snapshot may be mid-warm-up and re-run later before trusting the correlation evidence.

Respect the decision boundary

• **Risk-acceptance**, **remediation priority**, and any **regulatory / incident-response** call belong to the customer's security, compliance, and SOC functions. The assessment supplies evidence and a technical score.

Handle the output as sensitive

• The findings report maps your suite-wide weaknesses and privileged-access exposure. Store it in the restricted location (R6 / Global Requirements G7) and share on a need-to-know basis.

Where to go next (adjacent catalog areas)

• **Remediation Playbook for Defender Security Optimization Assessments** — closes the findings pilot-first, `-WhatIf`-gated, then re-scores. The natural next step.

• **Security Optimization Assessment — Defender for Cloud Apps** and **— Defender for Cloud** — the deep-dive assessments for those pillars.

• **Microsoft Defender XDR Deployment — Unified Onboarding** — if the assessment shows the suite is barely stitched together.

• **SOC Onboarding (Sentinel + Defender XDR)** and **Threat Hunting (KQL)** — to operationalize the correlated incidents once coverage is solid.

8. Deliverables Summary — Security Optimization Assessment: Microsoft Defender (Suite / XDR)

Documentation

Document	Purpose
Executive Summary	Business case and what's in the box — read-only suite assessment that scores posture and prioritizes gaps
1. Solution Overview	What Microsoft Defender XDR is, the four assessment domains (cross-pillar coverage, unified RBAC, incident correlation, suite-wide Secure Score), the scoring model, scope, and connections used
2. Requirements Guide	Solution-specific prerequisites with Verify / Implement-if-missing
Global Requirements (Assessments)	Category-wide prerequisites, published once
3. Implementation Guide	Exact, ordered steps to run the suite assessment end to end — Assess → Configure → Pilot → Validate → Expand — with every artifact named
5. Testing Guide	Eight validation tests with pass/fail gates proving the evidence is reliable
6. Troubleshooting Guide	Common run failures and fixes
7. Best Practices	Field-proven guidance and where to go next

PowerShell scripts (Microsoft Graph / Security + Az — all read-only)

Script	What it does
`SOAXDR-Discovery.ps1`	Read-only discovery — per-pillar onboarding/licensing signal (endpoint/identity/email/cloud-apps/cloud), unified-RBAC role assignments, incident-correlation evidence, and Microsoft Secure Score; saves the configuration baseline. Makes no changes.

Script	What it does
`SOAXDR-Validate.ps1`	Checks, per domain, whether the recommended controls are present (all in-scope pillars onboarded, unified RBAC activated with least-privilege roles, incidents correlating cross-pillar, Secure Score above a floor), returning Pass/Gap with evidence.
`SOAXDR-Score.ps1`	Computes deterministic per-domain and overall suite posture scores against the reference baseline using documented weights.
`SOAXDR-RBACAudit.ps1`	Read-only audit of privileged directory-role assignments relevant to the Defender suite — flags broad/over-privileged assignments (the unified-RBAC evidence).
`SOAXDR-Report.ps1`	Produces the prioritized, risk-ranked findings report (domain, severity, evidence, remediation/deep-dive pointer) and shows drift versus a prior saved baseline.

What the buyer receives

- This solution as a **Word** document and **PDF**.
- All five **PowerShell scripts** (read-only, Microsoft Graph / Security + Az) in a single ZIP.
- A repeatable process following **Assess** → **Configure** → **Pilot** → **Validate** → **Expand** — read-only, scored, and traceable, with findings ready to hand to the Remediation Playbook and the per-pillar deep-dive assessments.

Delivered as a **Complete Solution Package (PDF + Word + scripts)**.

Outcome

A scored, evidence-backed picture of your Microsoft Defender suite posture across cross-pillar coverage, unified RBAC, incident correlation, and suite-wide Secure Score — and a prioritized remediation backlog that tells you what to fix, in order. Read-only: it changes nothing, it tells you what to fix.

Appendix A — PowerShell Scripts

Included in the accompanying ZIP. Each script's header documents full usage.

SOAXDR-Discovery.ps1

Purpose: Read-only discovery for the "Security Optimization Assessment — Microsoft Defender (Suite/XDR)" solution. Enumerates, via Microsoft Graph (Security) + directory reads and Az: per-pillar onboarding/licensing signal (endpoint/identity/email/cloud-apps/cloud), privileged directory- role assignments (unified-RBAC evidence), unified security alerts/incidents (correlation evidence), and Microsoft Secure Score. Writes a JSON baseline (`Posture Baseline - Defender Suite - Assess`). Makes NO changes. HOW TO RUN Connect-MgGraph -Scopes "SecurityEvents.Read.All","RoleManagement.Read.Directory","Directory.Read.All" Connect-AzAccount # for the cloud pillar (optional if Azure not in use) powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File .\SOAXDR-Discovery.ps1 ` -OutputPath ".\Posture Baseline - Defender Suite - Assess.json" Read-only roles: Security Reader / Global Reader. EXPECTED RESULTS A JSON baseline with four domain sections and a per-pillar coverage map — the evidence scored by the rest of the assessment. .NOTES White-label. Read-only. Some per-pillar onboarding is confirmed in the portal Settings; where it cannot be read via Graph the script records a manual check. Licensing/preview facts flagged verify. > [CmdletBinding()] param([string]$OutputPath = ".\Posture Baseline - Defender Suite - Assess.json", [switch]$SkipAzure)

How to run: Connect-MgGraph -Scopes "SecurityEvents.Read.All","RoleManagement.Read.Directory","Directory.Read.All" Connect-AzAccount # for the cloud pillar (optional if Azure not in use) powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File .\SOAXDR-Discovery.ps1 ` -OutputPath ".\Posture Baseline - Defender Suite - Assess.json" Read-only roles: Security Reader / Global Reader. EXPECTED RESULTS A JSON baseline with four domain sections and a per-pillar coverage map — the evidence scored by the rest of the assessment. .NOTES White-label. Read-only. Some per-pillar onboarding is confirmed in the portal Settings; where it cannot be read via Graph the script records a manual check. Licensing/preview facts flagged verify. > [CmdletBinding()] param([string]$OutputPath = ".\Posture Baseline - Defender Suite - Assess.json", [switch]$SkipAzure)

SOAXDR-RBACAudit.ps1

Purpose: Enumerates directory-role assignments and highlights the security-relevant, high-privilege roles that govern who can see and act across the Defender suite (Global Administrator, Security Administrator, Security Operator, plus the read roles). Flags excessive Global Admins and standing high privilege — the evidence behind the unified-RBAC assessment domain. NO changes. HOW TO RUN Connect-MgGraph -Scopes "RoleManagement.Read.Directory","Directory.Read.All" powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File .\SOAXDR-RBACAudit.ps1 -OutputPath ".\rbac-audit.json" EXPECTED RESULTS A JSON list of privileged assignments grouped by role, with flags for over-privilege. An empty set (with a note) is valid in a tightly-scoped tenant. .NOTES White-label. Read-only. Flags are heuristic evidence for a human reviewer, NOT an automatic verdict — the security owner decides. Consider whether privileged roles are PIM-eligible (just-in- time) vs permanently active; permanent activation of high privilege is the higher-risk pattern. > [CmdletBinding()] param([int]$MaxGlobalAdmins = 5, [string]$OutputPath = ".\rbac-audit.json")

How to run: Connect-MgGraph -Scopes "RoleManagement.Read.Directory","Directory.Read.All" powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File .\SOAXDR-RBACAudit.ps1 -OutputPath ".\rbac-audit.json"

EXPECTED RESULTS A JSON list of privileged assignments grouped by role, with flags for over-privilege. An empty set (with a note) is valid in a tightly-scoped tenant. .NOTES White-label. Read-only. Flags are heuristic evidence for a human reviewer, NOT an automatic verdict — the security owner decides. Consider whether privileged roles are PIM-eligible (just-in- time) vs permanently active; permanent activation of high privilege is the higher-risk pattern. > [CmdletBinding()] param([int]$MaxGlobalAdmins = 5, [string]$OutputPath = ".\rbac-audit.json")

SOAXDR-Report.ps1

Purpose: Combines the validation output (Pass/Gap per control), the suite posture score, and the RBAC audit into a single prioritized findings report. Each finding carries: domain, severity, risk rank (severity x exposure), evidence, and a remediation pointer (to the Remediation Playbook, or to a per-pillar deep-dive assessment where the gap is a whole dark pillar). If a prior report is supplied, shows new / resolved / unchanged findings (drift). NO changes are made. HOW TO RUN powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File .\SOAXDR-Report.ps1 `-ValidationPath ".\SOAXDR-validation.json"` -ScorePath ".\Posture Score - Defender Suite - Pilot.json" `-RBACAuditPath ".\rbac-audit.json"` -PriorReportPath ".\Findings Report - Defender Suite - Validate (previous).json" ` -OutputPath ".\Findings Report - Defender Suite - Validate.json" -PriorReportPath is optional (omit on the first run). EXPECTED RESULTS A findings report (JSON + console summary) sorted by risk rank, with drift when a prior run is supplied. This is the backlog handed to the Remediation Playbook / deep-dive assessments. .NOTES White-label. Read-only. Risk-acceptance and remediation priority are the security owner's decisions — this report supplies the evidence and a suggested rank, not the authorization. > [CmdletBinding()] param([Parameter(Mandatory)][string]$ValidationPath, [Parameter(Mandatory)][string]$ScorePath, [string]$RBACAuditPath, [string]$PriorReportPath, [string]$OutputPath = ".\Findings Report - Defender Suite - Validate.json")

How to run: powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File .\SOAXDR-Report.ps1 `-ValidationPath ".\SOAXDR-validation.json"` -ScorePath ".\Posture Score - Defender Suite - Pilot.json" `-RBACAuditPath ".\rbac-audit.json"` -PriorReportPath ".\Findings Report - Defender Suite - Validate (previous).json" ` -OutputPath ".\Findings Report - Defender Suite - Validate.json" -PriorReportPath is optional (omit on the first run). EXPECTED RESULTS A findings report (JSON + console summary) sorted by risk rank, with drift when a prior run is supplied. This is the backlog handed to the Remediation Playbook / deep-dive assessments. .NOTES White-label. Read-only. Risk-acceptance and remediation priority are the security owner's decisions — this report supplies the evidence and a suggested rank, not the authorization. > [CmdletBinding()] param([Parameter(Mandatory)][string]$ValidationPath, [Parameter(Mandatory)][string]$ScorePath, [string]$RBACAuditPath, [string]$PriorReportPath, [string]$OutputPath = ".\Findings Report - Defender Suite - Validate.json")

SOAXDR-Score.ps1

Purpose: Consumes the validation output (SOAXDR-Validate.ps1) and computes a posture score per domain and an overall weighted suite score (0-100). Scoring is DETERMINISTIC for a fixed input so runs are comparable. Makes NO changes. HOW TO RUN powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File .\SOAXDR-Score.ps1 `-ValidationPath ".\SOAXDR-validation.json"` -OutputPath ".\Posture Score - Defender Suite - Pilot.json" SCORING MODEL (default weights — edit here to re-weight; record the change in SOA Scope): crossPillarCoverage = 35 (a dark pillar is a blind spot across the whole story) unifiedRbac = 25 (least-privilege cross-pillar access) incidentCorrelation = 20 (the XDR value-add — one story, not five silos) suiteSecureScore = 20 (headline suite posture) Domain score = (passed controls /

total controls) * 100. Overall = weighted average. EXPECTED RESULTS A JSON score record: per-domain score, weight, overall score, band, and run date. .NOTES White-label. Read-only. Baseline evolves — verify current Microsoft guidance each cycle. Weights are a starting point, not a mandate. > [CmdletBinding()] param([Parameter(Mandatory)][string]$ValidationPath, [string]$OutputPath = ".\Posture Score - Defender Suite - Pilot.json")

How to run: powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File .\SOAXDR-Score.ps1 `-ValidationPath ".\SOAXDR-validation.json"` -OutputPath ".\Posture Score - Defender Suite - Pilot.json" SCORING MODEL (default weights — edit here to re-weight; record the change in SOA Scope): crossPillarCoverage = 35 (a dark pillar is a blind spot across the whole story) unifiedRbac = 25 (least-privilege cross-pillar access) incidentCorrelation = 20 (the XDR value-add — one story, not five silos) suiteSecureScore = 20 (headline suite posture) Domain score = (passed controls / total controls) * 100. Overall = weighted average. EXPECTED RESULTS A JSON score record: per-domain score, weight, overall score, band, and run date. .NOTES White-label. Read-only. Baseline evolves — verify current Microsoft guidance each cycle. Weights are a starting point, not a mandate. > [CmdletBinding()] param([Parameter(Mandatory)][string]$ValidationPath, [string]$OutputPath = ".\Posture Score - Defender Suite - Pilot.json")

SOAXDR-Validate.ps1

Purpose: Consumes the baseline produced by SOAXDR-Discovery.ps1 (plus operator portal-confirmed inputs) and evaluates, per domain: - Cross-pillar coverage: all in-scope pillars onboarded - Unified RBAC: unified RBAC activated + no excessive Global Admins - Incident correlation: alerts span more than one pillar (serviceSource) - Suite-wide Secure Score: score above a floor Each check returns Pass or Gap WITH the evidence. Makes NO changes. HOW TO RUN powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File .\SOAXDR-Validate.ps1 `-BaselinePath ".\Posture Baseline - Defender Suite - Assess.json"` -PillarsOnboarded @('endpoint','identity','email','cloudapps','cloud') `-PillarsInScope @('endpoint','identity','email','cloudapps','cloud')` -UnifiedRbacActivated $true -SecureScoreFloor 70 -MaxGlobalAdmins 5 ` -OutputPath ".\SOAXDR-validation.json" EXPECTED RESULTS A per-domain Pass/Gap table with evidence — the input to SOAXDR-Score.ps1 and the report. .NOTES White-label. Read-only. Point-in-time snapshot. A dark/unlicensed pillar is a coverage finding (licensing has a cost the customer accepts). Mark truly N/A pillars out of scope. Verify current RBAC model and licensing facts. > [CmdletBinding()] param([Parameter(Mandatory)][string]$BaselinePath, [string[]]$PillarsInScope = @('endpoint','identity','email','cloudapps','cloud'), [string[]]$PillarsOnboarded = @(), [bool]$UnifiedRbacActivated = $false, [int]$SecureScoreFloor = 70, [int]$MaxGlobalAdmins = 5, [string]$OutputPath = ".\SOAXDR-validation.json")

How to run: powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File .\SOAXDR-Validate.ps1 `-BaselinePath ".\Posture Baseline - Defender Suite - Assess.json"` -PillarsOnboarded @('endpoint','identity','email','cloudapps','cloud') `-PillarsInScope @('endpoint','identity','email','cloudapps','cloud')` -UnifiedRbacActivated $true -SecureScoreFloor 70 -MaxGlobalAdmins 5 ` -OutputPath ".\SOAXDR-validation.json" EXPECTED RESULTS A per-domain Pass/Gap table with evidence — the input to SOAXDR-Score.ps1 and the report. .NOTES White-label. Read-only. Point-in-time snapshot. A dark/unlicensed pillar is a coverage finding (licensing has a cost the customer accepts). Mark truly N/A pillars out of scope. Verify current RBAC model and licensing facts. > [CmdletBinding()] param([Parameter(Mandatory)][string]$BaselinePath, [string[]]$PillarsInScope = @('endpoint','identity','email','cloudapps','cloud'), [string[]]$PillarsOnboarded = @(), [bool]$UnifiedRbacActivated = $false, [int]$SecureScoreFloor = 70, [int]$MaxGlobalAdmins = 5, [string]$OutputPath = ".\SOAXDR-validation.json")